

Shaping Narratives and Forging Control: The Dynamics of Culture and Power

“The state sought a careful balance between segregation and assimilation: while the reserves and missions operated to separate white and black society, the settlers could be reassured that Indigenous Queenslanders were sufficiently integrated into the values of white society to support patriotic endeavors” (Smith 2007, 56). This quote showcases how complex interplays between culture and power have been a recurring theme in colonial states. From there, the perpetuation of exclusion, violence, subjugation, discrimination, and precarity are also feasible because the relationship between the communities and the colonial power has already been established. In this analytical essay, we will delve into a comparative analysis of two distinct examples, each representing a different facet of this intricate relationship and offer us insights into the power dynamics surrounding cultural representation and female labor discipline, themes from Week #3 and Week #5, respectively.

To further the coherence of the analysis, focus points will allow us to anchor our arguments : the first being "false representation" or how the distortion of cultural identity and the misrepresentation of female labor, shedding light on how this phenomenon reinforces power structures. Next, we will shift our focus to "manipulation" and analyze how colonial authorities manipulated cultural representation to assert dominance over colonized populations and molded female labor into obedient and dedicated workers. Finally, we will address “dispossession” through both examples as a tool of marginalization of certain groups and devaluation and discipline of gendered labor.

In this essay, we draw upon "Colonialism on Display: Indigenous People and Artefacts as Australian Agriculture Show" written by Joanne Scott and Ross Laurie that sheds light on the Brisbane Exhibitions in the 20th century and how indigenous people created their own representation through material culture, but also upon "Census, Map, Museum" by Benedict Anderson, which examines the role of these institutions in shaping colonial and postcolonial power dynamics. Finally, we will also look over an excerpt from "Managing Women: Disciplining Labor in Modern Japan" by Elyssa Faison, exploring the role of female labor in Japan's industrial revolution during the Meiji period.

In our exploration of culture and power, the first connecting point that emerges is the issue of false representation. This phenomenon occurs when actions showcase the misunderstanding of their perpetrator and the contradiction with reality creates a gap in narratives. Both the Sarawak Colonial Museum and the Tomioka Silk Factory exemplify the distortion of cultural identity and the misrepresentation of female labor.

The Sarawak Colonial Museum, and more largely colonial museums detailed in Benedict Anderson's work, "Census, Map, Museum," reflect how colonial authorities fabricated and perpetuated a biased narrative about indigenous cultures. Indeed, gathering cultural symbols and establishing their own version of the local history allowed colonial states to invent and implement their own narrative (Anderson 1991, 255). This skewed representation was a means to assert control, reinforcing the colonial power dynamic by legitimizing cultural and moral supremacy. To do so, indigenous populations were depicted as uncivilized, primal, and divided to contrast with

the educated and unifier settlers. This misrepresentation continues to resonate in postcolonial contexts, as seen in the enduring cultural divisions among different ethnic groups in present-day Malaysia.

In contrast, late 19th century Japan employed the ideological framework of the "good wife, wise mother" to depict an idealized version of femininity that didn't align with the actual labor conditions faced by women. This false representation of womanhood advertised obedience, discretion and respect when the reality of industrial growth called for a new place for women in society (Faison 2007, 8). For example, the Tomioka silk factory, a central Japanese asset as textiles represented 50% of industrial revenue at the time (Faison 2007, 12), employed women under strict and harsh working conditions, proving the dependence of the state on their most often unrecognized work and the central role they played despite official discourse.

The theme of manipulation also emerges prominently in our analysis of culture and power as a tool of servitude and control over a population by shifting general opinion to induce a certain behavior on a given group.

In the Sarawak Colonial Museum example, the colonial authorities manipulated cultural representation as a tool to assert their dominance over colonized populations. The deliberate use of museums to collect and display cultural artifacts from colonized societies served as a means to showcase expertise and control. By monopolizing historical narration and influencing the culture of native communities, colonial settlers forced locals to change how they envisioned the state and their place in it, which had repercussions even beyond the colonial era. In truth nowadays in Malaysia governments, although not affiliated with colonial powers, are much less questioned than

in other democratic regimes and protests or visible political activism are rarer. This quote; "The colonial state's peculiar imagining of history and power... created a historical depth of field which was easily inherited by the state's postcolonial successor." (Anderson 1991, 255) clearly shows that assumption is not unique to this case. In fact, if other factors such as the predominant religion, the severity of punishments for breaking the law or the instability of the appointed governments surely influence the present situation, nonetheless a custom of political discretion established by colonial powers to gain more freedom in their measures must also play a role in political participation in neocolonial states.

On the other hand, if the Malaysian case takes the form of a mental battle, manipulation in Japan was very much physical. Indeed, the Tomioka Silk Factory implemented various measures to manipulate the female labor force such as containment within the factory, where high walls and gates limited their freedom and opportunities for disobedience, limited access to premises and paternalistic policies (Faison 2007, 17) to create a sense of dependency, emphasizing loyalty to the company and reducing opportunities for dissent or escape. This manipulation was integral to achieving the factory's economic and political goals in Meiji Japan (Faison 2007, 8) and sought to mold women into obedient and dedicated workers, thereby contributing to the industrialization of the country.

Dispossession is a recurring theme in both of the examples discussed above, exemplifying how power dynamics are embedded in colonial and industrial contexts, often leading to the marginalization and manipulation of certain groups. In the case of the Sarawak Colonial Museum, dispossession is evident through the appropriation of indigenous artifacts and cultural items by colonial authorities. The museum became a space for the colonial state to assert its control over

the colonized people and their culture (Anderson 1991, 254). The act of collecting and displaying these artifacts served to dispossess the indigenous communities of their heritage, as their cultural materials were taken and displayed without their proper consultation or consent. This dispossession not only stripped these communities of their cultural identity but also perpetuated the colonial narrative of dominance and superiority. Even today, the impact of this dispossession can still be seen in museums in former colonies, where indigenous cultures and their contributions are often marginalized or overlooked. However, this is not true for all states, for example, Aboriginal populations in Australia displayed the Brisbane exhibition 'eccentric' and 'authentically Aboriginal' artifacts to challenge perceptions and promote economic independence (Smith 2007, 47).

In the case of the Tomioka Silk Factory in early 20th century Japan, dispossession takes the form of the devaluation and discipline of gendered labor. The imposition of the "good wife, wise mother" ideal sought to redefine the parameters of Japanese womanhood (Faison 2007, 9), emphasizing qualities that aligned with the state's vision of compliant and dedicated female workers. Women were dispossessed of their autonomy and individuality, as they were expected to conform to these prescribed virtues both at work and at home. The paternalistic policies further reinforced a sense of dependency on the company, as basic needs were provided in a manner that cultivated loyalty and obligation among the workers, such as education, which young working women depended on their employer for (Faison 2007, 18). Furthermore, educating these women, which could be seen as a form of empowerment despite their lack of independence, was put in place in hopes of better controlling the free time of women (Faison 2008, 18). The dispossession of personal autonomy and freedom in favor of a disciplined, cohesive, and productive labor force served the economic and political goals of the time.

Both examples illustrate how, through the use of cultural appropriation in colonial museums and discipline of gendered labor in industrial contexts, dispossession becomes a fundamental aspect of power dynamics. By imposing external ideals in processes of internalization, these control mechanisms dispossess individuals and communities of their agency, identity, and freedom. This dispossession often has enduring effects that can be observed in contemporary society, as the impact of colonialism and industrialization continues to shape minds and cultures.

In conclusion, our comparative analysis of culture and power through the examination of two distinct examples - the Sarawak Colonial Museum in the context of cultural representation and the Tomioka Silk Factory in the context of female labor discipline - has shed light on the intricate relationship between culture and power in colonial and postcolonial contexts. The connecting points of false representation, manipulation, and dispossession have emerged as central themes in our analysis. False representation, as seen in the distortion of cultural identity and the misrepresentation of female labor, highlights how power structures are reinforced through the distortion of narratives and the imposition of biased perspectives. Manipulation, whether through the manipulation of cultural representation in colonial museums or the physical control of female labor in industrial settings, serves as a tool of dominance and control over marginalized populations. Finally, dispossession is another recurring theme, illustrating how power dynamics in colonial and industrial contexts often lead to the marginalization and manipulation of certain groups.

These examples underscore how culture and power are deeply entwined, impacting not only historical contexts but also leaving a lasting imprint on contemporary societies. The legacy of colonialism and industrialization continues to shape our world, reminding us of the need for critical analysis and awareness of the power dynamics embedded within our cultural narratives. In our ongoing exploration of culture and power, it is essential to remain vigilant in questioning representations, recognizing manipulations, and addressing dispossession to build a more equitable and just society.

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Sources

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